Q+A

BRUSH WITH SUFISM

Muzaffar Ali's upcoming exhibition fuses his passion for painting and cinema



Q.
What made you do a series of paintings on *Zooni* and what are your plans for them?
The artistic angst of an unfulfilled dream of the beauty of *Zooni*—my film about the 16th-century Kashmiri poet Habba Khatoon—and its setting has haunted me since I took on the project. The best way to manifest it today is through paintings, my original passion. I will be exhibiting four phases of *Zooni* at the first India Art, Architecture & Design Biennale being held at the Red Fort in New Delhi (December 9-15).

Q.
Why has your focus shifted to art and paintings of late?
All arts are one and integrated; and film is an integration of all arts. My ideas start with sketches and paintings and reach people through films. My paintings span multimedia, and are stylistically realistic and aesthetically abstract. There's a blend of beauty and mysticism. Like M.F. Husain, I have my own version of a horse, which recently also appeared as a bronze sculpture.

Q.
Which of these describes you best—author, filmmaker, fashion designer, culture revivalist or painter?
I would say that, above all, I'm a humane aesthete following my creative soul.

Q.
Will you be doing a film again? If yes, what about?
Of course. Film is the culmination of my sensibilities and my audiences are yearning for it every time I do a reading of my autobiography *Zikr: In the Light and Shade of Time* (2023). It will possibly be a film on Rumi. He is the need of the moment—we need to coexist to exist.

Photograph by **HARDIK CHHABRA**

with Shashi Sunny